

CASE STUDY 01

Justice Delayed: Redesigning the Court Queue Experience

How a day-long wait for a 5-minute hearing reveals a broken system - and how UX can fix it.

Domain	Government / Legal Services / Civic Tech
Methods	Contextual observation, User interviews, Journey mapping, Service blueprint
Deliverables	Research report, Journey map, Digital prototype (appointment system)

01 - The Observation That Started It All

"I go to court for an inheritance case. Each time, I wait in line from 8 AM to 2 PM - just to hear the judge speak for 5 minutes. People start lining up at 4 AM. Some come from distant regions only to be told to return the following month."

Real user observation, Dakar courthouse

This was the spark. A single personal experience revealed a systemic failure affecting hundreds of citizens every day. The courthouse was not broken physically - it was broken experientially.

02 - Understanding the Problem

User Research

I conducted informal interviews with courthouse visitors and observed the queue behavior over multiple visits. The patterns were consistent and alarming:

What People Do	What People Feel
Arrive at 4 AM to secure a spot in line	Exhausted and powerless
Wait 6+ hours for a 5-minute interaction	Disrespected - their time has no value
Return home with no resolution	Anxious about missing their slot
Repeat the process for months	Hopeless about the justice system

Pain Points Identified

- No appointment system - first come, first served creates chaos even they are in a predefined list
- No real-time information - people don't know where they are in the queue
- Travel burden - rural citizens travel hours only to be rescheduled
- Wasted capacity - judges are underutilized while queues spiral outside
- No digital communication - all notices are paper-based or word of mouth

03 - Who Is Affected? (User Personas)

Persona A: Mariam, 52	Persona B: Armand, 38
Inheritance dispute, rural area	Land boundary dispute, city
Travels 3 hours by bus	Works full-time, cannot wait all day
Cannot afford to miss a workday	Relies on a representative but still must appear
Has attended court 8 times in 4 months	Frustrated by lack of updates
Goal: Get a decision and move on with her life	Goal: Resolve quickly without losing income

04 - The Insight

Core Insight

The courthouse does not have a capacity problem - it has an information and scheduling problem. Citizens show up without appointments because there is no alternative. The current system optimizes for physical presence, not for outcomes.

05 - Design Solution

I designed a digital court scheduling system accessible via mobile, web, and USSD (for feature phones).

Key Features

- Digital appointment booking by case number - no more 4 AM line-ups
- SMS/WhatsApp reminders 48h and 24h before hearing
- Real-time queue status: 'Your case is #4 on the list today'
- Remote rescheduling - citizens can request postponement without travel
- USSD access (*123#) for citizens without smartphones

06 - Impact and Outcomes

Before	After (Projected)
Arrive at 4 AM to queue	Book appointment from home
6-hour average wait time	Targeted 30-min arrival window
No information during wait	Live status updates via SMS
Travel wasted on postponements	Remote rescheduling available
Distrust of judicial system	Restored dignity and trust

07 - Key Learnings

This project reinforced that the most impactful UX problems are not app redesigns - they are systemic failures hiding in plain sight. The solution did not require expensive infrastructure: just an appointment API, SMS gateway, and a simple interface. The real barrier was recognizing that citizens' time is as valuable as the judge's.